

Blizzard Hernando

After-Action Report

July 2026

BARNSTABLE COUNTY

CAPE COD REGIONAL GOVERNMENT

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Preface

This document was developed by the Barnstable County Department of Emergency Management and Department of Health and Environment to support the County of Barnstable with identifying lessons learned and opportunities for improvement in response to the February 23, 2026 blizzard, unofficially named Blizzard "Hernando". It is consistent with guidelines established by the federal Homeland Security Exercise and Evaluation Program (HSEEP) and Continuous Improvement Program (CIP).

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Executive Summary

Beginning Sunday evening, February 22, 2026, Blizzard Hernando struck Cape Cod and the Islands, bringing hurricane-force wind gusts, heavy wet snow totaling 15–22 inches across the region, and widespread power outages. At the height of the storm, 153,000 customers were without power across Cape Cod, with upwards of 100% of the Outer Cape region without power. In collaboration with the Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee (BCREPC), Barnstable County staff and members of the All Hazards Incident Management Team (BCAHIMT) activated the Multi-Agency Coordination Center (MACC), coordinated four regional shelters and at least 14 local warming centers, and worked alongside approximately 200 local, county, state, nonprofit, and utility partners through more than 11 regional coordination calls over five days. Family Table Collaborative distributed 17,000 meals. The Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority provided hundreds of rides. Eighteen AmeriCorps Cape Cod members supported shelters and the MACC throughout the response.

This After-Action Report (AAR) documents findings from the county's post-incident review process, conducted in accordance with FEMA's Continuous Improvement Technical Assistance Program (CITAP) guidance. Data were collected through an internal hotwash, targeted stakeholder sessions with town health agents, emergency management directors, community partner organizations, an AmeriCorps member session, and multiple surveys yielding more than 60 responses.[1]

The review identified 7 Focus Areas and 29 findings. The table below summarizes all findings and key recommendations by focus area. The Focus Areas are:

1. Sheltering
2. Communications
3. Information Technology (IT) and Infrastructure
4. Administration and Finance
5. Mobilization and Demobilization
6. MACC Operations
7. Organizational Culture

Full analysis, supporting observations, and detailed recommendations follow in the body of the report.

Finding	Category	Finding	Key Recommendation(s)
Focus Area 1: Sheltering			
1.1	Potential Best Practice	Several locally driven shelter models demonstrated strong performance	Document the Dennis-Yarmouth self-sufficient feeding model and

[1]Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), After-Action Review User Guide (Washington, D.C.: FEMA Continuous Improvement Technical Assistance Program, November 2023), https://preptoolkit.fema.gov/web/cip-citap.

Finding	Category	Finding	Key Recommendation(s)
		and represented practices worth formalizing and replicating across the region.	Provincetown self-sufficient shelter model as replicable practices; formally integrate both into the revised Regional Sheltering Plan.
1.2	Area for Improvement	Physical readiness of shelter facilities, supply inventories, and backup power has not been systematically verified, and supply deployment logistics are inflexible.	Establish an annual pre-storm inspection protocol; evaluate transition to deployable shelter support trailers.
1.3	Area for Improvement	Pre-established facility use agreements at school-based shelter sites are no longer active or current.	Develop updated pre-event facility use agreements specifying room-by-room authorization and a single point of facility authority.
1.4	Area for Improvement	Volunteer and staff identification at shelter sites was inconsistent or absent, with no standard credentialing or role-differentiation system in place.	Support the adoption of a standard credentialing and identification protocol across all shelter sites; ensure on-site orientation for all arriving personnel
1.5	Area for Improvement	No formal demobilization planning process existed at shelter intake, leaving some residents without arrangements for home access or transportation at closure.	Add a discharge planning element to the shelter intake process; develop pre-event demobilization coordination protocols with towns.
1.6	Area for Improvement	The county's partnership with the American Red Cross would benefit from updated agreements and clearer role definitions.	Engage Red Cross regional leadership to negotiate updated MOAs that define specific shelter management deliverables.
1.7	Area for Improvement	Untapped institutional and community capacity exists that could significantly strengthen shelter staffing and medical support if pre-event relationships and processes are established.	Support each sub-region in developing a locally driven shelter staffing model; develop a county-level surge capacity plan including volunteer reception center capability; explore relationships with untapped groups.
1.8	Mission Critical	Roles and responsibilities for regional sheltering are not well socialized, regional agreements within the	Execute MOAs with towns and partner agencies defining county support roles; develop job action sheets for all

Finding	Category	Finding	Key Recommendation(s)
		BCREPC are not current, and the county engaged without signed agreements defining its role, forcing AmeriCorps into operational roles it should not have been filling.	shelter positions; review volunteer and staff liability framework.
1.9	Mission Critical	The 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan has not been socialized, practiced, or updated to reflect current operational realities, and does not reflect a framework in which local sheltering authority and responsibility remain with municipalities.	Comprehensively revise the Regional Sheltering Plan as a framework for scaling local capacity to a regional system; develop MOAs with each sub-regional arrangement; build a hurricane-season staffing contingency that does not rely on AmeriCorps.
1.10	Mission Critical	Medical and behavioral health staffing at shelters was critically inadequate, and no pre-established model existed for determining minimum medical staffing requirements.	Develop a minimum medical staffing standard (at minimum one RN and one CNA per activation) and integrate into shelter planning documents and MOUs.
1.11	Mission Critical	Shelter food service lacked enough ServSafe-certified staff.	Require at minimum one ServSafe-certified staff member per shelter site as part of shelter activation staffing requirements. Engage health agents for food safety oversite at shelters.
Focus Area 2: Communications			
2.1	Strength	The emergency communications plan and Sitrep template in place proved effective throughout the activation and represent a foundation worth sustaining and updating.	Formally review and update the emergency communications plan; codify the Sitrep template and distribution protocol as a standard attachment.
2.2	Potential Best Practice	The emergency communications plan and Sitrep template proved effective throughout the activation.	Formally review and update the emergency communications plan annually.
2.3	Area for Improvement	The Public Information Officer function lacks the staffing depth and pre-event structure needed to sustain operations during a multi-day activation.	Designate a formal Assistant PIO role; establish a pre-event communications team with pre-assigned roles activated at storm watch issuance; develop a

Finding	Category	Finding	Key Recommendation(s)
			social media monitoring and misinformation response protocol.
2.4	Area for Improvement	The county has no degraded communications protocol and key backup communications assets are not integrated into response planning.	Develop a degraded communications protocol; pre-position satellite connectivity resources; integrate the AM radio station into the emergency communications plan with defined activation triggers.
2.5	Area for Improvement	Multilingual and culturally accessible communications remain a gap, leaving non-English-speaking and immigrant-community residents without adequate information access.	Develop multilingual templates in Portuguese, Spanish, and Arabic; procure a website translation widget; build immigrant community relationships through established community organizations.
2.6	Area for Improvement	Health agents were not regularly communicated with by the county or integrated into the response through the Health Agents Coalition.	Formally incorporate health agent notification and coordination as a key response support role for the County Department of Health and Environment; develop job action sheets for health agents within the shelter ICS structure.
Focus Area 3: IT and Infrastructure			
3.1	Area for Improvement	Barnstable County IT's recovery work had no pathway into MACC situational awareness, and IT's role in activations is not formally defined.	Formally assign IT a defined role within the MACC/EOC structure; integrate GIS and IT dashboarding into operational workflows.
Focus Area 4: Administration and Finance			
4.1	Area for Improvement	Administrative and finance functions were not embedded in the MACC from the outset, creating FEMA reimbursement documentation gaps.	Establish a standard that a dedicated finance function is embedded in the MACC from activation start.
Focus Area 5: Mobilization and Demobilization			
5.1	Strength	The transition of MACC leadership during an extended activation was	Develop a documented staff rotation plan for extended activations,

Finding	Category	Finding	Key Recommendation(s)
		handled effectively and illustrates the value of having staff rotation protocols established before they are needed.	including defined trigger points for command transition and handoff procedures; incorporate extended activation scenarios into the annual exercise cycle.
5.2	Area for Improvement	No formal activation protocol, pre-agreed trigger thresholds, or demobilization procedures existed, resulting in staggered and inconsistent shelter openings and unclear closure processes.	Support the development of a town-led regional shelter activation matrix with pre-established trigger thresholds and pre-assigned responsibilities; develop a formal demobilization checklist covering supply disposition and resident discharge coordination.
Focus Area 6: MACC Operations			
6.1	Potential Best Practice	The BCREPC has an opportunity to strengthen its role as a regional preparedness coordination body and improve the regional call structure used during activations.	Support the BCREPC in developing an annual Integrated Preparedness Plan using the HSEEP IPPW framework; work with BCREPC to restructure storm response calls around a community lifelines model.
6.2	Strength	Family Table Collaborative and Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority, among other external partners, performed reliably and their roles should be more formalized.	Review and update MOAs with CCRTA and Family Table Collaborative to formalize their roles in future activations.
6.3	Area for Improvement	County MACC/EOC use of WebEOC was not consistently integrated into operations, and no standardized inter-agency communication protocol existed among volunteer and partner organizations.	Establish a standard that all MACC activities be documented through WebEOC; ensure all relevant staff are trained and proficient before next storm season.
6.4	Area for Improvement	Established county service resources could be more fully integrated into emergency response to help residents connect with available services and support.	Develop a protocol for activating county helpline and resource referral services; strengthen coordination with Mass 211.

Finding	Category	Finding	Key Recommendation(s)
6.5	Area for Improvement	The county has no formal relationship with Massachusetts VOAD, limiting access to statewide mutual aid and shared volunteer pools when local capacity is exceeded.	Pursue formal membership and active participation in Massachusetts VOAD.
6.6	Area for Improvement	The regional equipment cache provides a critical regional resource but its storage and maintenance infrastructure requires modernization.	Pursue funding and capital planning for a climate-controlled storage facility to more effectively house, maintain, and distribute the regional equipment cache; transition from Conex box storage to a trailer-based deployment model.
6.7	Mission Critical	The county lacks a formalized Incident Support Model (ISM), resulting in improvised command arrangements, undefined departmental roles, and no established protocols for extended activation staffing or overnight MACC continuity.	Formalize the ISM; develop a MACC overnight and extended-activation staffing model; establish clear protocols for elected official participation during activations.
Focus Area 7: Organizational Culture			
7.1	Area for Improvement	County staff lack the training, credentialing, and role clarity needed to fill emergency MACC or EOC positions effectively.	Require ICS 100, 200, 700, and 800 as baseline certifications; develop a county-wide staff skills inventory; develop and distribute job action sheets.

Incident Overview

On Saturday, February 21, 2026, the Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee (BCREPC) convened the first regional coordination call as forecast confidence in a major Cape impact increased, with approximately 200 participants joining. By Sunday evening, county staff and the Barnstable County All-Hazards Incident Management Team (BCAHIMT) had stood up the Multi-Agency Coordination Center (MACC), with Andrew Platt and Michael Walker assuming command. Initial storm tracking earlier in the week had suggested a likely offshore track, but by Thursday and Friday trajectory models shifted decisively: wind speed projections climbed toward hurricane-force gusts and a rain-snow line positioned just below Nantucket confirmed the Cape would receive heavy, wet snow rather than lighter accumulations.

Blizzard Hernando struck Cape Cod beginning Sunday night into Monday, February 23, bringing blizzard conditions with wind gusts up to 60–75 mph, heavy wet snowfall totaling 15–22 inches across the region (higher on the Upper Cape), and widespread coastal flooding. The storm rapidly intensified offshore and peak conditions, including near-zero visibility and snowfall rates of 3–4 inches per hour, persisted through Monday morning and early afternoon. At the height of the storm, 153,000 customers were without power across Cape Cod.

Four regional shelters opened across Cape Cod and the Islands, along with at least 14 local warming centers and charging stations, and at least two local community shelters. Nauset Regional High School in Eastham was the first shelter activated (Sunday evening), followed by Barnstable Intermediate School. Nauset was subsequently closed mid-storm after its heating system was found to be nonfunctional on generator power following recent renovations; all residents were transported by the Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority (CCRTA) to Dennis–Yarmouth Regional High School. Cape Cod Regional Technical High School (Cape Tech, in Harwich) opened Tuesday evening as an additional regional shelter, and the Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe's Community and Government Center and the Provincetown Community Center provided local shelter capacity. At peak, Dennis–Yarmouth had over 250 residents and Barnstable had over 150.

Approximately 200 local, county, state, nonprofit, and utility partners joined regional coordination calls twice daily. Eighteen AmeriCorps Cape Cod members supported shelters, and the MACC. Eversource deployed approximately 2,000-line crews statewide, with additional mutual aid crews from across the Northeast and Canada. Family Table Collaborative distributed 17,000 meals with support from local and national food partners, including World Central Kitchen, which deployed to the Cape beginning February 25. The CCRTA provided hundreds of rides transporting residents and pets to shelters and supported meal deliveries. The Cape Cod Medical Reserve Corps was unable to mobilize at meaningful scale. Telecommunications outages, including cellular and internet failures across multiple towns, significantly impaired operations.

Leadership at the MACC transitioned from Andrew Platt and Michael Walker to Vaira Harik on Thursday, February 26, after approximately 96 hours of continuous operations. The three remaining regional shelters (Dennis–Yarmouth, Barnstable Intermediate, and Cape Tech) closed Friday, February 27, at 1:00

PM as power restoration progressed and shelter census numbers declined. The state travel ban for Barnstable County had been lifted Monday, February 24, at noon.

Timeline of Key Events

Date/Period	Key Events
Week prior (Sat.–Sun.)	Storm initially tracks offshore; no activation actions taken. By Thursday–Friday, forecast track shifts toward direct Cape impact; wind projections climb toward hurricane force; rain-snow line positions below Nantucket confirming heavy, wet snow.
Sat., Feb. 21	BCREPC convenes first regional coordination call (~200 participants). Blizzard Warning issued for Barnstable and Dukes Counties. Eversource issues 8% power outage forecast, widely viewed internally as a significant underestimate. State of Emergency declared; MEMA activates.
Sun., Feb. 22 (evening)	MACC activates (5:00 PM); Andrew Platt and Michael Walker assume command. Nauset Regional High School (Eastham) opens as first regional shelter at 6:00 PM. Barnstable Intermediate School opens at 8:00 PM. Steamship Authority suspends service. CCRTA suspends regular service; shelter transport to begin when safe. Eversource activates Level 4 Emergency Response Plan. Snow begins.
Mon., Feb. 23	Blizzard conditions peak (7 AM–early afternoon); wind gusts 60–75 mph, snowfall rates 3–4 inches/hour. Nauset Regional High School heating failure was discovered (connection issue with generator after renovations). Dennis-Yarmouth Regional High School shelter opens at 8:00 PM. 153,000 customers are without power at peak. Travel ban in effect. Widespread telecom outages begin.
Tues., Feb. 24	Statewide travel ban lifted (noon). Nauset Regional High School shelter closes with CCRTA transporting clients to Dennis-Yarmouth Regional High School shelter. Cape Tech (Harwich) opens as additional regional shelter at 8:00 PM. Shelter population: Dennis–Yarmouth 175, Barnstable 100. Family Table Collaborative distributing 5,000–6,000 meals per day. Power restoration is ongoing. CCRTA transport line active.
Wed., Feb. 25	Barnstable County offices remain closed. Power restoration continues; secondary roads remain narrowed or blocked. World Central Kitchen deploys to Cape Cod. Three regional shelters operational: Dennis–Yarmouth, Barnstable Intermediate, Cape Tech. BCREPC coordination calls continue twice daily.
Thurs., Feb. 26	County and MACC leadership transitions from Andrew Platt and Michael Walker (respectively) to Vaira Harik at 2:00 PM. Shelter census declines. Shelter closure was announced for Feb. 27 at 1:00 PM.
Fri., Feb. 27 (1:00 PM)	All three remaining regional shelters close: Dennis–Yarmouth, Barnstable Intermediate, Cape Tech. RTA provides transportation assistance. MACC demobilization begins. Six regional shelters served hundreds of residents over five days.

Methodology and Data Collection

This after-action review was conducted in accordance with FEMA's CITAP After-Action Review User Guide.

Data Collection Methods

Method	Description
Internal Hotwash (April 3, 2026)	Facilitated session with county staff using breakout groups by functional area (Shelter Operations, Communications, Administrative Support, Center Support/IT/Infrastructure, Logistics). Modified SWOT framework. Approximately 20 participants.
County Staff Survey	Anonymous online survey (Likert-scale, multiple-choice, short-response). Approximately 16 responses.
Health Agents AAR Session (April 15, 2026)	Virtual session with town health agents from across Barnstable County. Approximately 15 participants.
Emergency Management Directors AAR Session (April 30, 2026)	Virtual session with town EMDs from across Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee municipalities. Approximately 10 participants.
Community Partner Organizations AAR Session (May 4, 2026)	Virtual roundtable with the American Red Cross, Regional Transit Authority, Family Table Collaborative, Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe, ARES/RACES, Salvation Army, and others. Approximately 20 participants.
AmeriCorps Member AAR Session (May 11, 2026)	Facilitated session with AmeriCorps members, alumni, and advisory board representatives. Approximately 25 participants.
Post-Session Surveys	Online surveys distributed following each external session. Total survey responses across all instruments exceeded 60.
Documentation Review	Review of the 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan, existing MOAs, internal communications, situation reports, and other planning documents.

Finding Categories

Findings are categorized using the four-tier framework from FEMA's National Continuous Improvement Guidance and CITAP After-Action Review User Guide.

Mission Critical	Issues with significant operational effects that may lead to mission failure or harm. Require immediate attention from senior leadership.
Area for Improvement	Activities that resulted in outcomes that did not meet expectations.

Strength	Activities within policy or guidance that yielded the desired result. Should be sustained and institutionalized.
Potential Best Practice	Activities outside established policy that yielded better results than expected and are worthy of broader adoption.

Response Highlights

Blizzard Hernando was a serious, multi-day regional emergency that tested every component of Barnstable County's emergency management system. Viewed from the outside, and by most objective measures, the response succeeded: shelters opened, residents were served, meals were delivered, transportation was arranged, and the region recovered without loss of life attributable to the response. The findings that follow describe the gaps that those on the inside recognized: the structural problems that made an effective response harder than it needed to be and that could produce worse outcomes in a more severe event.

Before turning to those gaps, it is important to document what worked. The commitment and adaptability of the people involved was extraordinary and consistent across every data collection method.

Volunteer and Staff Commitment

The single most frequently cited strength of the response was the dedication of state, county, and town staff, volunteers, and community partners who stepped far outside their normal roles over five days. In the Multi-Agency Coordination Center and Regional Shelters, staff and volunteers worked shifts in some cases exceeding 20 hours at a time. AmeriCorps members absorbed responsibilities to fill critical gaps. AmeriCorps alumni and Advisory Board members deployed voluntarily to regional shelters, demonstrating that their service pledge continues. This extraordinary commitment compensated for structural gaps that formal planning must address before the next event.

School Partners

School district staff, nurses, custodians, facilities managers, and administrators, were among the most reliable and effective partners of the response. For example, at Dennis–Yarmouth, the school district provided its own kitchen staff and nurses, operated its own food supply chain, and maintained thorough intake documentation. Barnstable School District staff, Nauset Regional School District staff, and Cape Cod Tech staff remained actively engaged throughout, coordinating volunteers and resolving operational issues. School nurses at multiple sites provided clinical continuity that no outside resource could have replicated. These contributions represent the kind of locally driven capacity the region needs to build upon.

Town and Community Partner Performance

Several town and community partners performed reliably throughout the response:

- Town Police, Fire Rescue, Health, Emergency Management, Departments of Public Works, and other departments worked tirelessly to support their communities and address critical needs following the blizzard.
- Family Table Collaborative distributed 17,000 meals over five days with support from World Central Kitchen, local restaurants, and national food partners.

- The Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority (CCRTA) provided hundreds of rides transporting residents and pets to shelters, supported meal deliveries, and executed the emergency transfer of Nauset residents to Dennis–Yarmouth mid-storm without incident.
- The Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe's Community and Government Center and the Provincetown Community Center provided local shelter capacity without drawing on regional resources.
- The Salvation Army provided shelter supply support across the region. Multiple mutual aid organizations responded to resource requests within the operational period.
- The American Red Cross filled staffing needs at multiple Cape Cod shelter locations while also serving as the primary agency for multiple off-Cape community shelters.

Recognition from Legislative Representatives and Community Leaders

Following Blizzard Hernando, the region's response received recognition from state legislative representatives and community leaders who noted the effectiveness of the BCREPC coordination structure and the regional sheltering response. From the community's perspective, and by the standard of whether residents were sheltered, fed, and transported safely, the response succeeded. The purpose of this after-action report is to ensure the next response succeeds by design rather than by the extraordinary effort of individuals compensating for structural gaps.

Findings and Recommendations

This section presents all 29 findings from the County's Blizzard Hernando after-action review, organized by focus area. Each finding includes the validated finding statement, supporting observations drawn verbatim from the Initial Observations Matrix, an analysis section grounded in relevant best practices and guidance, and specific recommendations. Finding and recommendation language is preserved verbatim from the validated Initial Findings Report.

Focus Area 1: Sheltering

Sheltering was the highest-volume and most consequential focus area of this review. The blizzard stressed the county's regional sheltering system at virtually every operational level. Sixteen findings emerged from this focus area, including ten that identify structural and systemic gaps requiring action before the next activation season.[2]

Finding 1.1 –Potential Best Practice

Several locally driven shelter models demonstrated strong performance and represented practices worth formalizing and replicating across the region.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #1 [Strength]:** Early shelter activation (pre-storm) significantly reduced logistical burden and allowed setup to proceed in safer conditions, enabling more effective resident reception.

> **Observation #2 [Potential Best Practice]:** Dennis-Yarmouth Regional High School was self-sufficient for feeding, deploying its own kitchen staff and food supplies without relying on regional resourcing.

> **Observation #3 [Potential Best Practice]:** Provincetown operated a self-sufficient local shelter, with a commercial kitchen, thorough intake documentation and strong public safety support, providing a model for both local shelter self-sufficiency and evidence-based population planning.

Analysis

The strongest shelter performances during Blizzard Hernando shared a set of common features: preemptive activation before storm conditions made setup dangerous, self-sufficient food service using local kitchen staff and supply chains, thorough intake documentation that produced actionable population data, and strong public safety support. These are not difficult practices; they are the predictable outputs of deliberate pre-event planning and relationship-building.

[2]Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee (BCREPC), Barnstable County Regional Sheltering Plan (Barnstable, MA: BCREPC, 2017). On file with Barnstable County Emergency Management Division.

Pre-established agreements enabled the Dennis-Yarmouth model: because the school district had its own kitchen staff, its own supply chain, and staff engaged in shelter planning, that part of its activation was more self-sufficient, taking the strain off regional resources.

Recommendations

1. Support preemptive shelter activation as a standard approach and memorialize in any the revised regional sheltering framework.
2. Document the Dennis-Yarmouth self-sufficient feeding shelter model as a replicable practice and share across sub-regions through the BCREPC.
3. Provide training and resources to standardize intake data collection for shelter sites, including overnight counts, age ranges, medical device dependency, and prescription management needs in any revision to the regional sheltering framework.
4. Formally integrate the Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe's Community and Government Center and Provincetown shelter into the regional sheltering framework, including appropriate MOAs and resource support.

Finding 1.2 – Area for Improvement

Physical readiness of shelter facilities, supply inventories, and backup power has not been systematically verified, and supply deployment logistics are inflexible.

Supporting Observations

Observation #9 [Area for Improvement]: Conex box shelter supplies at multiple sites were found to be moldy, mildewed, and unready for use; food warmers were non-functional; no standardized supply inspection or inventory process exists; inventories were not posted externally; and demobilization procedures were unclear, including what supplies to repack, discard, or donate.

Observation #10 [Mission Critical]: Heating system at Nauset Regional High School was not connected to generator power, forcing emergency closure and transfer of all residents mid-storm.

Observation #34 [Area for Improvement]: Shelter cots were described as largely inaccessible to elderly residents: low to the ground, difficult to get on and off, and of insufficient weight capacity; bariatric cots were absent.

Observation #35 [Area for Improvement]: There were no walkie-talkies in shelters, forcing staff to rely on limited school-owned radios or personal cell phones for internal communications within large buildings where medical emergencies occurred far from support stations.

Observation #47 [Mission Critical]: Barnstable Intermediate School bathroom facilities are a long distance from the sleeping area, requiring wheelchairs to be consumed for toilet runs and leaving truly immobile residents unserved. Bathrooms were also designed more for younger children, creating additional functional and access needs issues.

Analysis

The American Red Cross pre-inspection checklist for shelter facilities includes generator-connected equipment testing, cot inventory verification, kitchen equipment functionality, and ADA accessibility assessment as baseline requirements before a facility is activated. None of these appear to have been systematically applied to designated shelter sites in recent years.

The fixed Conex box storage model compounds these gaps: supplies cannot be re-routed to meet unanticipated needs at other sites, and the absence of posted manifests means arriving staff have no reliable way of knowing what they have available. Transitioning to deployable shelter support trailers that can be dispatched as flexible resources to any activation site is a model worth evaluating as a long-term improvement.

Recommendations

1. Establish an annual pre-storm-season inspection protocol for all designated shelter facilities, covering interior space readiness, generator function, kitchen and shower access, and ADA compliance.
2. Work with host municipalities to establish annual blackout tests of generator systems at all designated shelter facilities.
3. Evaluate converting the county's shelter supply model from fixed Conex boxes to deployable shelter support trailers, scaled by capacity, that can be dispatched as a flexible resource to any activation site; conduct a full supply audit as the first step.
4. Pending any supply model transition, post a current manifest within each Conex box and review cot inventory to ensure elderly-accessible and bariatric options are available.
5. Add walkie-talkies to standard shelter supply inventory for internal site communications.

Finding 1.3 – Area for Improvement

Pre-established facility use agreements at school-based shelter sites are no longer active or current, and without them operational decisions around room access, authorization chains, and facility authority during activations are unclear.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #48 [Area for Improvement]:** No pre-established written agreement defined which rooms at school-based shelter facilities would open and in what sequence during an activation, resulting in custodians and school resource officers having to open spaces in an ad hoc basis.

> **Observation #54 [Mission Critical]:** Shelter food service had no requirement or verification process for ServSafe-certified staff, no reliable plan for food reheating at some generator-only sites, increasing the risk for foodborne illness incidents among medically vulnerable residents.

Analysis

Pre-established facility agreements are a core element of shelter planning. Agreements should define facility use terms, operational authority during an activation, cost recovery expectations, and the sequence of space authorization. School-based shelter sites present a particular complexity because they involve multiple institutional authorities: school districts, municipal governments, and emergency management agencies, with overlapping but sometimes conflicting roles and priorities.

Recommendations

1. Support the development of updated pre-event facility use agreements or annexes for each school-based shelter site specifying room-by-room authorization, capacity expansion sequencing, and a single point of facility authority during activations.
2. Ensure school district administrators at all designated shelter sites are included in shelter planning, exercises, and future AAR processes as formal participants.

Finding 1.4 – Area for Improvement

Volunteer and staff identification at shelter sites was inconsistent or absent, with no standard credentialing or role-differentiation system in place.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #55 [Area for Improvement]:** Volunteer and staff identification at shelter sites was inconsistent or absent, with no standard credential display system in place; nurses rotated without identification, residents could not distinguish clinical staff from volunteers, and there was no formal sign-in and sign-out process enforced at some shelter entrances.

Analysis

NIMS establishes that accountability, including personnel tracking, check-in/check-out procedures, and role identification, is a core principle of incident management. The American Red Cross Shelter Operations Toolkit specifies that all shelter staff and volunteers should display visible identification that allows shelter residents to distinguish trained responders from other volunteers and from residents. At multiple shelter sites, no such system existed, creating safety and accountability gaps that complicated medical care, shift changes, and resource tracking throughout the activation.

Recommendations

1. Support the adoption of a standard credentialing and identification protocol across all shelter sites, such as color-coded vests or role-specific lanyards differentiating medical, logistics, registration, and operations personnel.
2. Include a formal shelter staff sign-in and sign-out process in all shelter job action sheets.
3. Ensure on-site orientation for all arriving personnel, including those deployed mid-activation, includes identification and role assignment.

Finding 1.5 – Area for Improvement

No formal discharge planning process existed at shelter intake, leaving some residents without arrangements for home access or transportation at closure.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #53 [Area for Improvement]:** No formal discharge planning was conducted with shelter residents at intake, meaning many residents lacked arrangements for home access, transportation, or family pickup at closure, requiring ad hoc phone calls during demobilization and in some cases extending shelter operations.

Analysis

Discharge planning at intake is a well-established practice in both healthcare and emergency shelter management. The Red Cross shelter intake process includes a section on post-shelter needs, and FEMA's Mass Care guidance addresses the importance of tracking residents' ability to return home as a component of shelter demobilization planning. Adding a brief discharge assessment at intake significantly reduces the complexity of shelter closure and prevents situations where residents have nowhere to go when a shelter demobilizes.

Recommendations

1. Add a discharge planning element to the shelter intake process covering home access, power status, transportation, and family contact.
2. Develop pre-event discharge coordination protocols with towns for residents who cannot return home at shelter closure.

Finding 1.6 – Area for Improvement

The county's partnership with the American Red Cross would benefit from updated agreements and clearer role definitions to ensure consistent and well-coordinated shelter support, including improved information sharing during activations.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #32 [Area for Improvement]:** The American Red Cross' volunteer collaboration with AmeriCorps members on site was at times contentious; those deployed from off Cape were not aware of the role of AmeriCorps.

Analysis

The American Red Cross is a critical partner in the county's regional sheltering system, and the 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan designates specific ARC responsibilities at designated shelter sites. The gap between those designated responsibilities and the reality of a deployment which brings in off-Cape support, points to a partnership that needs a refresh.

ARC's operational constraints are real: its ground stop policy prohibits asking volunteers to travel during dangerous conditions, and its liability framework shapes what tasks its trained volunteers will perform.

These constraints are legitimate and manageable, but they require explicit documentation in pre-event MOAs so that all parties understand what ARC can and cannot provide during different phases of an event and what contingency arrangements exist when ARC delivery is limited.

Recommendations

1. Engage Red Cross regional leadership to negotiate updated MOAs that define specific shelter management deliverables, require participation in all-hands shelter briefings and shared information calls, and establish interoperable or shared registration access for shelter command staff.
2. Include Red Cross roles explicitly in sub-regional shelter plans and functional exercises to build shared understanding before the next event.
3. Develop a contingency staffing plan for shelter management functions that does not assume full Red Cross delivery at every site.

Finding 1.7 – Area for Improvement

Untapped institutional and community capacity exists that could significantly strengthen shelter staffing and medical support if pre-event relationships and processes are established.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #12 [Area for Improvement]:** Multiple CERT teams and numerous VOAD organizations have effectively disintegrated over the past four years due to COVID-era attrition, significantly reducing volunteer surge capacity; compounding this, no call-down list was activated during the blizzard, meaning willing and available individuals were never contacted and potential surge capacity went untapped.

> **Observation #64 [Area for Improvement]:** Untapped institutional capacity exists in organizations not currently integrated into regional shelter planning, including Cape Cod Community College, Massachusetts Maritime Academy, and Cape Cod Tech's CNA cohort, which could provide trained personnel, facilities, or logistical support if CORIs and municipal linkages were addressed.

Analysis

The attrition of some CERT teams and VOAD organizations since 2020 has reduced the region's volunteer surge capacity significantly. At the same time, organizations with substantial relevant capacity, such as Cape Cod Community College, Massachusetts Maritime Academy, and Cape Cod Tech's CNA cohort, remain outside the regional sheltering framework.

National VOAD research on disaster volunteerism consistently finds that willing volunteers go undeployed not because they are unavailable but because no system exists to receive them. Building the capacity to receive and integrate volunteers before a disaster is as important as identifying the volunteers themselves.

Recommendations

1. Support each sub-region in developing a locally driven shelter staffing model that provides a resilient command structure drawn from town employees, CERT teams, and local volunteers; county resources are intended to supplement that local foundation, not substitute for it.
2. Develop a county-level surge capacity plan including volunteer reception center capability to process, credential, background check, and provide just-in-time training to spontaneous and out-of-area volunteers before they enter shelter environments.
3. Explore relationships with Cape Cod Community College, Massachusetts Maritime Academy, and Cape Tech CNA cohort as potential sources of trained personnel and logistical support.

Finding 1.8 – Mission Critical

Roles and responsibilities for regional sheltering are not well socialized, regional agreements within the BCREPC are not current, and the county engaged without signed agreements defining its role, forcing AmeriCorps into operational roles it should not have been filling.

Supporting Observations

Observation #5 [Mission Critical]: No formal ICS structure or shelter command role (branch director or equivalent) was in place at multiple shelter sites; partner organizations were left to self-organize, resulting in unclear span of control, no job action sheets, no volunteer credentialing, and no single point of accountability.

Observation #6 [Mission Critical]: AmeriCorps members were de facto placed in charge of shelter operations at multiple sites, receiving little on-site orientation, no job action sheets, and no formal handoff, despite explicit program commitments that they would not carry operational responsibility.

Observation #33 [Mission Critical]: AmeriCorps members and other untrained personnel were required to perform personal care tasks, including assisting with toileting, changing adult diapers, and cleaning human waste, for which they had no training and which fall outside their program scope.

Observation #39 [Mission Critical]: The roles and responsibilities of county, volunteers, versus town personnel at shelters were unclear to nearly all survey respondents, creating confusion, gaps in accountability, and duplication, particularly around food service, medical care, registration, and cleaning.

Observation #63 [Mission Critical]: No pre-established conditions or MOU defined what operational infrastructure must be in place at a shelter before AmeriCorps members would be deployed, leaving members without a mechanism to decline unsafe or out-of-scope assignments and the county without a clear service standard against which partner performance could be measured.

Analysis

NIMS and the National Response Framework establish that role clarity, pre-assigned responsibilities, and a defined command structure are foundational requirements for effective emergency response. The American Red Cross Shelter Operations Toolkit specifies that every activated shelter should have a

designated shelter manager with defined authority and a written job action sheet for each functional position. At multiple Barnstable County shelter sites during Blizzard Hernando, none of these elements were in place.[34]

The absence of pre-established roles created a structural vacuum that AmeriCorps members filled by default. This dynamic is well-documented in disaster response research: when formal command structures are absent, whoever is physically present and willing takes on responsibility regardless of training or authority. The county's exposure is compounded by the undefined liability framework for volunteers and staff performing tasks outside their scope, which the county must address before the next activation season.

Recommendations

1. Execute Memoranda of Agreement (MOAs) with each town and partner agency (Red Cross, AmeriCorps, Medical Reserve Corps (MRC)) clearly defining county support roles and mutual responsibilities at each level of regional shelter activation.
2. Develop and make available job action sheets for all shelter positions as a resource for sub-regions to adapt and use.
3. Recommend best practices for shift management at shelter sites, including maximum shift lengths and shift briefing protocols, for adoption by sub-regions through their local plans.
4. Work with human resources and county counsel to review and define the framework for volunteer and staff roles, scope of care, and associated liability considerations before next activation season.

Finding 1.9 – Mission Critical

The 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan has not been socialized, practiced, or updated to reflect current operational realities, and does not reflect a framework in which local sheltering authority and responsibility remain with municipalities.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #4 [Mission Critical]:** The Barnstable County Regional Sheltering Plan, last updated in 2017, does not reflect current volunteer capacities, ICS expectations, or organizational structure.

> **Observation #40 [Area for Improvement]:** The County has no staffing capability to support shelters during peak hurricane season (August-September) when AmeriCorps members may not be available or are in their first weeks of service, a significant structural vulnerability given AmeriCorps has become load-bearing for shelter operations.

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[3]Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), National Incident Management System, 3rd ed. (Washington, D.C.: FEMA, 2017), https://www.fema.gov/sites/default/files/2020-07/fema_nims_doctrine-2017.pdf.

[4]American Red Cross, Shelter Operations Toolkit (Washington, D.C.: American Red Cross, 2022). The ARC Mass Care toolkit defines shelter roles, staffing ratios, and inter-agency coordination expectations for Red Cross-supported shelter activations.

Observation #51 [Mission Critical]: AmeriCorps have not regularly taken part in shelter exercises as part of their training since COVID, meaning they had never practiced opening a shelter, locating equipment, navigating facilities, or coordinating under realistic conditions before doing so during a multi-day blizzard.

Observation #58 [Area for Improvement]: No formal activation protocol, pre-agreed trip wires, or trigger thresholds for shelter pre-opening existed, resulting in staggered and inconsistent openings that created public confusion about where and when shelters were available.

Analysis

The Comprehensive Preparedness Guide (CPG) 101 establishes that emergency plans must be regularly updated, exercised, and socialized with all implementing partners to remain operationally relevant. A plan that sits on a hard drive, unreviewed for nearly a decade and unknown to most of its implementing partners, provides no operational benefit when a storm makes landfall. The 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan was developed in a different operational environment: prior to the current AmeriCorps deployment model, prior to the COVID-era disintegration of volunteer organizations, and prior to the demographic shifts that have made the Cape's shelter population older and more medically complex.[5]

The erosion of pre-established activation thresholds compounds this gap. The REPC-endorsed trigger framework from the post-2013 Blizzard Nemo era gave EMDs clear, pre-agreed decision points. Without it, every activation decision becomes an improvised judgment call under time pressure, with inconsistent results that create public confusion and operational friction at the moments when clarity is most important.

Recommendations

1. Work with the BCREPC, the American Red Cross, and partner agencies to comprehensively revise the Regional Sheltering Plan as a framework for scaling local sheltering capacity to a regional system when municipal resources are overwhelmed, rather than a plan that replaces local sheltering responsibility.
2. Develop MOAs with each sub-regional shelter arrangement defining roles, responsibilities, and the conditions under which county and regional support is activated.
3. Work with each sub-region to incorporate a regional shelter activation functional exercise into its preparedness cycle, involving towns, AmeriCorps, and partner agencies.
4. Develop a hurricane-season staffing contingency that does not rely on AmeriCorps as a primary operational resource.

Finding 1.10 – Mission Critical

[5]Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), Comprehensive Preparedness Guide (CPG) 101: Developing and Maintaining Emergency Operations Plans, Version 3.0 (Washington, D.C.: FEMA, May 2025), https://www.fema.gov/sites/default/files/documents/fema_cpg-101-v3-developing-maintaining-eops.pdf.

Medical and behavioral health staffing at shelters was critically inadequate, and no protocols exist for the high-acuity medical situations that recur predictably in this region's shelter population.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #7 [Mission Critical]:** Multiple shelter sites lacked adequate medical and mental health staffing.

> **Observation #46 [Mission Critical]:** Multiple group homes and home health agencies dropped clients at shelters without staff, supplies, or medical information, leaving AmeriCorps members to manage those clients.

> **Observation #60 [Mission Critical]:** Shelters had no plan for specific high-acuity medical situations that recurred across multiple sites and activations, including methadone treatment access for individuals in medication-assisted treatment programs, management of residents with advanced dementia, and dialysis-dependent patients.

Analysis

The American Red Cross Functional Needs Support Services (FNSS) guidance establishes that general population shelters must be capable of serving individuals with diverse access and functional needs, including medical, cognitive, and physical disabilities. Cape Cod's demographic profile, a year-round population skewing significantly older than the state average, with high rates of medical device dependency and chronic illness, making FNSS compliance not a policy aspiration but an operational baseline. The situations that recurred across shelter sites during Blizzard Hernando, including methadone treatment access, advanced dementia management, and care for dialysis-dependent residents, are predictable features of this region's shelter population, not edge cases.[6]

Resource management for populations with access and functional needs is critical to an effective mass care program. The absence of such protocols, combined with the absence of Medical Reserve Corps volunteers at multiple shelters, left AmeriCorps members and other untrained staff as the de facto care givers for a medically complex population.

Recommendations

1. Develop a minimum medical staffing standard (at minimum one RN and one CNA per activation) and incorporate it into the revised Regional Sheltering Plan.
2. Pilot contracted arrangements with home care agencies as a reliable per-shelter medical staffing source.

[6]American Red Cross, Functional Needs Support Services (FNSS) in General Population Shelters: A Reference Guide (Washington, D.C.: American Red Cross, 2012). FNSS guidance establishes the expectation that general population shelters be capable of serving individuals with a broad range of access and functional needs, including medical, cognitive, and physical disabilities.

3. Establish an advance communication protocol with Cape Cod Hospital for shelter-bound patient transfers, including acuity information and escort coordination.
4. Formally include behavioral health professionals and social workers in shelter staffing plans and job action sheets.
5. Develop shelter protocols for predictable scenarios including medication-assisted treatment access, advanced dementia management, and dialysis-dependent residents.

Finding 1.11 – Mission Critical

Shelter food service lacked enough ServSafe-certified staff.

Supporting Observations

Observation #9 [Area for Improvement]: Conex box shelter supplies at multiple sites were found to be moldy, mildewed, and unready for use; food warmers were non-functional; no standardized supply inspection or inventory process exists; inventories were not posted externally; and demobilization procedures were unclear, including what supplies to repack, discard, or donate.

Observation #54 [Mission Critical]: The Regional Shelter Plan had no formal requirement or verification process for ServSafe-certified staff, relying on AmeriCorps and other volunteers who happened to have the certification.

Analysis

American Red Cross food safety standards require at minimum one food-safety-certified supervisor per meal service and verification of food holding temperatures prior to service. At Cape Tech, ovens were non-functional under generator power, meaning food had to be microwaved to be served.

The ServSafe certification program provides nationally recognized food safety training specifically designed for emergency and institutional food service contexts. Requiring at least one certified staff member per shelter site is a minimal, low-cost standard that directly addresses the food safety gaps observed during Blizzard Hernando. Health agents, who hold authority over food safety and sanitation, provide a natural enforcement mechanism when incorporated into shelter activation protocols as recommended in Finding 1.8.

Recommendations

1. Require at minimum one ServSafe-certified staff member per shelter site as part of the shelter staffing standard.
2. Verify food service equipment function, including oven and food warmer operation on generator power, as part of the annual pre-season site inspection protocol.
3. Coordinate with health agents to establish a food safety verification protocol at shelter activation.
4. Expand ServSafe training offerings across the region.

Focus Area 2: Communications

The communications focus area encompasses both internal county coordination and external public-facing communications. Blizzard Hernando exposed significant vulnerabilities in communications team structure, backup capability, and multilingual outreach, while also confirming the strength of the county's existing emergency communications plan and demonstrating a promising AI-assisted workflow innovation.

Finding 2.1 – Strength

The emergency communications plan and Sitrep template in place proved effective throughout the activation and represent a foundation worth sustaining and updating.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #13 [Strength]:** An emergency communications plan built during COVID provided a known activation framework, and the Sitrep template ensured consistent, well-received reporting throughout the event.

Analysis

The county's COVID-era emergency communications plan provided a known activation framework that was recognized and applied by communications staff during Blizzard Hernando. The Sitrep template (consistent format, predictable cadence, clear distribution) drew independent praise from town staff across multiple AAR sessions. This kind of institutional knowledge, built through sustained practice, is difficult to recreate once lost and should be protected through formal documentation and regular review.

Recommendations

1. Formally review and update the emergency communications plan; codify the Sitrep template and distribution protocol as a standard attachment.

Finding 2.2 – Potential Best Practice

The use of AI tools by the PIO to organize notes and produce Situation Reports more efficiently represents a potential best practice for county emergency communications.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #14 [Potential Best Practice]:** AI tools were used by the PIO to organize notes and produce Sitreps more quickly, reducing cognitive load during a high-stress operational period.

Analysis

The use of AI drafting assistance during Blizzard Hernando represents an early and appropriate application of emerging technology in emergency communications. The application was suitable: the AI was used for note organization and drafting support, with human review and finalization by the PIO. This workflow has meaningful potential to reduce cognitive load during extended activations and improve

documentation quality and consistency. It also carries risks, including factual errors, inappropriate tone, unreviewed outputs, which require explicit guidance and quality control before broader adoption.

Recommendations

1. Document the AI-assisted workflow in writing.
2. Develop guidance on appropriate use and quality control to prevent errors or misuse.
3. Train additional communications staff on the workflow.

Finding 2.3 – Area for Improvement

The County's Public Information Officer (PIO) function lacks the staffing depth and pre-event structure to sustain operations during a multi-day activation.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #15 [Area for Improvement]:** The communications team was assembled informally at the last minute via individual phone calls, with no pre-assigned roles, no call-down tree, and no Assistant PIO designation, requiring the PIO to recognize almost immediately that the role could not be filled alone.

> **Observation #19 [Area for Improvement]:** No social media monitoring role was designated during the event, requiring ad hoc identification and correction of misinformation without a clear process, and a coordinating Teams channel was not created until Thursday of the operational period.

Analysis

The expectation that a single PIO can identify and assemble a communications team by phone at the onset of a major storm, while simultaneously beginning operational communications, is inconsistent with ICS design. Pre-event team assembly, maintained call-down lists, and standing templates for predictable scenarios are baseline elements of a functional emergency communications program.

The Blizzard Hernando experience reflects a communications function built for routine communications rather than extended emergency activations. FEMA guidance on exercise programs recommends regular exercises of emergency communications plans, including call-down drills, as a mechanism for maintaining team readiness between events.

Recommendations

1. Designate a formal Assistant PIO role and establish a pre-event communications team with pre-assigned roles, activated at storm watch issuance.
2. Coordinate with the regional communications working group to support PIO coordination across towns during activations and maintain a common operating picture regionally.
3. Develop a social media monitoring and misinformation response protocol; establish a standing procedure to activate a coordination channel pre-event.
4. Develop and maintain pre-event social media templates and graphics for predictable emergency scenarios.

5. Conduct regular exercises of the emergency communications plan including internal call-down drills.

Finding 2.4 – Area for Improvement

The county has no degraded communications protocol and key backup communications assets are not integrated into response planning.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #16 [Area for Improvement]:** Widespread telecommunications outages (internet and cell) severely impaired operations across multiple towns and shelter sites, and no backup communications protocol existed; when connectivity failed there were no pre-established alternatives.

> **Observation #17 [Area for Improvement]:** The county AM radio station has been available for over a year but has not been activated, advertised, or integrated into emergency communications planning, representing a critical unused asset for reaching elderly and non-digital populations.

Analysis

Emergency communications systems must include redundant capabilities and communications plans must address scenarios involving degraded or failed primary communications infrastructure. The Blizzard Hernando experience describes a communications function with no meaningful backup layer. ARES participants noted that had the storm lasted 6–12 more hours, complete cellular failure across the Cape was a realistic outcome.

The county AM radio station represents an immediately available asset for reaching elderly and non-digital populations.

Recommendations

1. Develop a degraded communications protocol defining analog backup procedures for loss of internet or cellular service, including paper-based fallback processes.
2. Pre-position satellite connectivity resources with key staff before anticipated high-impact events.
3. Develop a non-emergency programming strategy for the county AM radio station to build listenership before the next event, and integrate the station into the emergency communications plan with defined activation triggers.
4. Verify and document ham radio capability at all shelter sites.
5. Work with state and federal partners to advocate for stronger regional telecommunications infrastructure resilience.

Finding 2.5 – Area for Improvement

Multilingual and culturally accessible communications remain a gap, leaving non-English-speaking and immigrant-community residents without adequate information access.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #11 [Area for Improvement]:** Immigrant community members avoided shelters due to fear of federal immigration enforcement, leaving vulnerable individuals without access to essential services.

> **Observation #18 [Area for Improvement]:** Multilingual communications remain an unaddressed gap; non-English speaking residents were not adequately served by any communications channel during the event.

Analysis

Immigrant community members who avoided shelters during Blizzard Hernando due to fear of federal enforcement were not an unforeseen population; they are a known, vulnerable component of the Cape's year-round residential community. Translation services and equipment already exist within county government and partner organizations but were not systematically deployed.

Building trust with communities requires ongoing relationship investment through established community organizations, not just translated materials issued at storm onset. The trust-building dimension of this work cannot begin during a storm; it must be part of the County's year-round preparedness mission.

Recommendations

1. Develop multilingual communications templates for predictable emergency scenarios in Portuguese, Spanish, and Arabic at minimum.
2. Procure a website accessibility translation widget.
3. Develop a community outreach and trust-building strategy with immigrant communities in partnership with town health agents and established community organizations.

Finding 2.6 – Area for Improvement

Health agents were not regularly communicated with by the county or integrated into the response through the Health Agents Coalition.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #8 [Area for Improvement]:** The Health Agents Coalition, made up the local public health professionals with direct authority over shelter food safety, sanitation, and occupancy conditions, were not notified or communicated with during the blizzard response by the County.

Analysis

Town health agents are key public health professionals who hold direct authority over the conditions that matter most in a shelter setting: food safety, sanitation, communicable disease risk, and occupancy conditions. The 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan already designates a health agent role within the shelter ICS structure.

The health agent AAR session revealed that health agents had both the skills and the willingness to engage during Blizzard Hernando, as several deployed voluntarily, but received little to no

communication from the regional Health Agents Coalition from the County. This is directly addressable through updates to activation protocols and a revised internal framework for communications.

Recommendations

1. Formally incorporate health agent notification and coordination as a key support role for the Department of Health and Environment.
2. Develop job action sheets for health agents operating within the shelter ICS structure.
3. Ensure the inclusion of health agents in any regional shelter functional exercises.

Focus Area 3: IT and Infrastructure

Information technology and communications infrastructure played an unexpectedly central role in shaping the Blizzard Hernando response. Widespread failure of telecommunications infrastructure, combined with the absence of a defined role for Barnstable County IT within the MACC structure, created significant operational gaps.

Finding 3.1 – Area for Improvement

Barnstable County IT's extensive recovery work during the blizzard had no pathway into MACC/EOC situational awareness, and IT's role in activations is not formally defined.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #20 [Strength]:** County campus IT infrastructure remained online throughout the event, and self-reporting infrastructure provided remote visibility into system status.

> **Observation #21 [Area for Improvement]:** IT recovery work in towns by Barnstable County IT staff had no direct pathway into the MACC information flow, limiting situational awareness at the coordination center.

Analysis

The county's IT department performed substantial and operationally significant work during Blizzard Hernando: maintaining county campus infrastructure, supporting towns, and managing remote system visibility. None of this information had a formal pathway into MACC situational awareness. GIS and IT dashboarding resources that could have supported a common operating picture were not integrated into operational workflows.

Recommendations

1. Formally assign IT a defined role within the MACC/EOC structure at defined activation levels.
2. Integrate GIS and IT mapping and dashboarding resources into MACC/EOC operational workflows.
3. Investigate regional IT manager participation in organized mutual aid.
4. Work with state and federal partners to advocate for stronger regional telecommunications infrastructure resilience.

Focus Area 4: Administration and Finance

Administrative and finance functions are foundational to every emergency activation. During Blizzard Hernando, neither was embedded in the MACC from the outset, creating documentation gaps with implications for FEMA Public Assistance reimbursement eligibility.

Finding 4.1 – Area for Improvement

Administrative and finance support functions were not embedded in the MACC/EOC from the outset of the activation, creating gaps in FEMA reimbursement documentation and cost tracking that were only partially resolved by the end of the event.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #22 [Area for Improvement]:** No standardized process existed for tracking staff time or resource expenditures for FEMA reimbursement purposes; staff were not uniformly notified to track hours from the start of the activation.

> **Observation #23 [Area for Improvement]:** While an emergency purchasing workflow exists, there is no dedicated emergency fund accessible to county departments for rapid response expenditures.

Analysis

FEMA Public Assistance reimbursement eligibility requires contemporaneous documentation: staff sign-ins from the moment of activation, procurement records tied to the disaster event, and resource tracking that begins at hour one. NIMS identifies administration, finance, and logistics as core emergency management capabilities that must be activated alongside, not after, operational functions. The Finance/Administration Section is a defined ICS function precisely because these requirements cannot be retroactively satisfied.

The absence of a dedicated emergency fund with an appropriate emergency purchase and authorization workflow reflects a broader gap in pre-event financial preparedness. Both are standard elements of emergency management financial planning that can be established administratively without significant resource investment.

Recommendations

1. Establish a standard that a dedicated finance and administrative function is embedded in the MACC/EOC from activation start, with a defined responsible person and documented procedures for procurement tracking, sign-ins, and cost documentation.
2. Develop a notification template directing all deployed staff to track hours from the moment of activation for FEMA reimbursement eligibility.
3. Review and update the county's existing emergency purchasing policy to confirm it is current and accessible to relevant staff before the next activation.

Focus Area 5: Mobilization and Demobilization

Both the front end and back end of the Blizzard Hernando response were affected by the absence of formal protocols. The lack of pre-agreed activation thresholds contributed to staggered and inconsistent shelter openings, while the absence of demobilization procedures complicated closure processes and supply disposition.

Finding 5.1 – Strength

The transition of MACC leadership during an extended activation was handled effectively and illustrates the value of having staff rotation.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #25 [Strength]:** MACC leadership transitioned smoothly from one team to the next on Thursday after approximately 96 hours of continuous operations, with conversations underway about protocols for staff rotation in extended activations.

Analysis

The smooth transition from one MACC leadership team to the next at approximately hour 96 is an operational success of Blizzard Hernando. ICS design accounts for extended activations through formal command transfer protocols, including situation briefings, transfer of command documentation, and overlap periods to ensure continuity.

Recommendations

1. Develop a documented staff rotation plan for extended activations, including defined trigger points for command transition and handoff procedures.
2. Incorporate extended activation scenarios into the annual exercise cycle.

Finding 5.2 – Area for Improvement

No formal activation protocol, pre-agreed trigger thresholds, or demobilization procedures existed, resulting in staggered and inconsistent shelter openings, public confusion, and unclear closure processes.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #24 [Area for Improvement]:** Eversource's forecast of an 8% power outage rate (issued Saturday) was widely viewed internally as a significant underestimate, potentially contributing to complacency in early mobilization decisions.

> **Observation #58 [Area for Improvement]:** No formal activation protocol, pre-agreed trip wires, or trigger thresholds for shelter pre-opening existed; shelter opening decisions were made individually by town fire/police chiefs in informal consultation with the MACC, resulting in staggered and inconsistent openings that created public confusion about where and when shelters were available.

Analysis

Pre-established activation thresholds and trigger criteria as essential elements of an operational plan, as decisions made in advance under deliberate conditions are consistently better than decisions improvised under operational pressure.

Demobilization is equally important and equally under-planned. Conex box supply disposition, resident discharge coordination, and facility restoration are all predictable demobilization tasks that can be pre-specified in a checklist, eliminating the need for real-time improvisation at the end of a long activation.

Recommendations

1. Support the development of a town-led regional shelter activation matrix with pre-established trigger thresholds and pre-assigned responsibilities, socialized annually across the region.
2. Develop a formal demobilization checklist covering supply repack, donation, discard decisions, and resident discharge coordination.

Focus Area 6: MACC Operations

The MACC Operations focus area addresses how Barnstable County coordinated the regional response at the Multi-Agency Coordination Center level, encompassing command structure, operational tools, partner coordination, and regional relationships.

Finding 6.1 – Potential Best Practice

The BCREPC has an opportunity to strengthen its role as a regional preparedness coordination body and improve the regional call structure used during activations.

Supporting Observations

Observation #28 [Area for Improvement]: REPC meeting attendance drops to approximately 15 participants during non-emergency periods versus approximately 300 during events, limiting inter-agency coordination effectiveness during the preparedness phase. The large calls were at times difficult to keep on track due to the number of speakers.

Observation #30 [Potential Best Practice]: Regional coordination through twice-daily REPC calls during the event was cited as effective for situational awareness and information sharing across towns and agencies, though the number and length of calls was at times excessive.

Analysis

The BCREPC's twice-daily operational calls during Blizzard Hernando drew approximately 300 participants and were consistently cited as one of the most effective coordination mechanisms of the response. BCREPC attendance during non-emergency periods is approximately 15. This attendance gap is not a failure of the BCREPC; it reflects a structural challenge common to regional coordination bodies nationwide: the urgency of an emergency drives participation in ways that routine preparedness work cannot replicate.

An Integrated Preparedness Planning Workshop (IPPW) framework provides a structured method for regional bodies to develop multi-year preparedness plans with defined priorities, shared exercises, and measurable outputs. Structuring storm response calls around FEMA's Community Lifelines model, with functional working groups reporting out to a consolidated call, improving both information quality and call efficiency for the approximately 300 participants who join during activations.

Recommendations

1. Support the BCREPC in developing an annual Integrated Preparedness Plan (IPP) using the HSEEP Integrated Preparedness Planning Workshop (IPPW) framework, establishing a multi-year schedule of preparedness activities with defined priorities and outputs.
2. Support efforts to help member communities understand the BCREPC's role and how it complements, but does not replace, each town's statutory obligations under the Civil Defense Act and EPCRA.

3. Support the BCREPC in structuring storm response communications around a community lifelines model, with functional coordination occurring in smaller working groups that report out to a single consolidated BCREPC call in a listen-and-brief out format; codify the participant list, cadence, and brief out format so the structure is ready before the next activation.

Finding 6.2 – Strength

Family Table Collaborative and Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority, among other external partners, performed reliably and their roles should be more formalized.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #31 [Strength]:** Family Table Collaborative and Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority (CCRTA) were cited as highly effective and reliable external partners; RTA drivers provided critical resident transport throughout the response.

Analysis

The Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority and Family Table Collaborative were cited consistently and independently across every AAR session as the most reliable operational partners of Blizzard Hernando. RTA provided critical resident transport throughout the event, including the emergency transfer of Nauset residents during the mid-storm heating failure. Family Table Collaborative distributed 17,000 meals over five days with support from World Central Kitchen and local partners. These organizations demonstrated exactly what effective pre-established partnerships look like in practice: clear roles, reliable delivery, no coordination friction.

Formalizing these relationships through updated MOAs ensures that the operational clarity that emerged from years of working relationships is documented and transferable, rather than dependent on the continued availability of the same individuals.

Recommendations

1. Review and update MOAs with CCRTA and Family Table Collaborative to formalize their roles in future activations.

Finding 6.3 – Area for Improvement

County MACC/EOC use of WebEOC was not consistently integrated into operations, and no standardized inter-agency communication protocol existed among volunteer and partner organizations.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #27 [Area for Improvement]:** WebEOC, available for resource tracking, shelter management, inter-agency communication, and event logging, was underutilized during the response.

> **Observation #52 [Area for Improvement]:** No standardized inter-agency communication protocol existed among MRC, Red Cross, and AmeriCorps, resulting in deployment requests managed through multiple parallel systems, volunteer arrival and departure not tracked by receiving shelters, and a single MRC Coordinator managing all scheduling for most of the incident.

Analysis

WebEOC is MEMA's designated statewide platform for resource tracking, event logging, and inter-agency coordination. Its underutilization during Blizzard Hernando, while parallel systems (email, Google Forms, MA Responds) were used simultaneously by different partners, created information fragmentation that made resource tracking unreliable and documentation incomplete.

Proficiency in WebEOC's deployment functions requires dedicated training well before activation season rather than first-use learning during an active event.

Recommendations

1. Establish a standard that all MACC/EOC activities, resource requests, and resource tracking be documented through WebEOC during activations; where WebEOC can perform a function, it should be used rather than creating parallel systems.
2. Ensure all relevant county and municipal staff are trained and proficient in WebEOC before next storm season; conduct MA Responds training specifically for deployment functions for the MRC Coordinator and a designated backup well before activation season.
3. Establish a mechanism for each operational shelter to provide a direct situational report into MACC/EOC calls, either through a designated shelter liaison or a pre-call WebEOC summary.

Finding 6.4 – Area for Improvement

Established county service resources could be more fully integrated into emergency response to help residents connect with available services and support.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #27 [Area for Improvement]:** County help lines were not formally activated and information sharing with Mass 211 was inconsistent resulting in incorrect information being shared.

Analysis

County helplines represent existing infrastructure within the County with direct applicability to emergency response that was not activated during Blizzard Hernando. Mass 211, the statewide resource and referral service, was not coordinated with county activities despite being the primary public-facing resource connection point during disasters. These are not new investments; they are existing assets with established infrastructure and staff that require activation protocols and inter-departmental coordination to function during emergencies.

Recommendations

1. Develop a protocol for activating county helpline and resource referral services during emergencies to provide residents with direct connection to available services.
2. Strengthen coordination with Mass 211 to ensure the state's resource and referral service is aligned with regional activities and able to support residents during activations.
3. Work across relevant county departments to define how their resources and capacities integrate into MACC/EOC support functions during activations.

Finding 6.5 – Area for Improvement

The county has no formal relationship with Massachusetts VOAD, limiting access to statewide mutual aid and shared volunteer pools when local capacity is exceeded.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #57 [Area for Improvement]:** The county has no formal relationship with Massachusetts VOAD as an active participating member, limiting access to statewide mutual aid, shared volunteer pools, and inter-agency coordination resources.

Analysis

Cape Cod's geographic isolation (a peninsula with limited road access) creates both a self-reliance culture and a structural vulnerability. When the 72 hour local self-sufficiency window passes and outside assistance arrives, communities without a structure for receiving that assistance consistently see resources arrive and sit idle. National VOAD research documents this pattern across multiple major disasters. Massachusetts VOAD membership provides access to statewide mutual aid networks, shared volunteer pools, and inter-agency coordination resources at minimal cost and with immediate practical value.

Recommendations

1. Pursue formal membership and active participation in Massachusetts VOAD as a low-cost, high-value investment in statewide mutual aid access.
2. Develop a structured capacity for receiving and integrating outside assistance when it arrives, to avoid the pattern observed in other events where resources arrived but had no operational home.

Finding 6.6 – Area for Improvement

The regional equipment cache provides a critical regional resource but its storage and maintenance infrastructure requires modernization.

Supporting Observations

> **Observation #9 [Area for Improvement]:** Conex box shelter supplies at multiple sites were found to be moldy, mildewed, and unready for use; food warmers were non-functional; no standardized supply inspection or inventory process exists; inventories were not posted externally; and demobilization

procedures were unclear, including what supplies to repack, discard, or donate. Two of the three County emergency generators were found to not be operational at the onset of the event.

Observation #44 [Area for Improvement]: The MACC facility itself was cited as inadequate and in need of replacement.

Analysis

The Conex box storage model's limitations were made operational during Blizzard Hernando: moldy and mildewed supplies deployed to medically vulnerable populations, food warmers non-functional, no external manifests, and fixed-location staging that could not adapt to unanticipated demand at alternate sites. Two of the three County emergency generators were found to not be operational at the onset of the event. These are not new problems; they are the predictable consequences of inadequate maintenance and an inflexible deployment model. Climate-controlled storage and a trailer-based deployment model are capital investments with direct operational returns that align with the county's obligations under the Southeast Region Homeland Security Advisory Council MOU.

Recommendations

1. Pursue funding and capital planning for a climate-controlled storage facility to more effectively house, maintain, and distribute the regional equipment cache assets in a manner consistent with county obligations under the SRAC MOU.
2. Evaluate transition from Conex box storage to a trailer-based deployment model to provide scalable, flexible support to activations of varying sizes.
3. Ensure annual inventory and maintenance requirements under the SRAC MOU are being met and documented.

Finding 6.7 – Mission Critical

The county lacks a formalized Incident Support Model (ISM), resulting in improvised command arrangements, undefined departmental roles, and no established protocols for extended activation staffing or overnight MACC continuity.

Supporting Observations

Observation #26 [Area for Improvement]: The county lacked a formalized Incident Support Model (ISM) defining roles and responsibilities for all county departments within the MACC structure, resulting in improvised command arrangements during the blizzard.

Observation #38 [Area for Improvement]: The MACC lost phone capability overnight during the event; when shelter staff contacted the MACC at night, resource requests were reportedly met with a negative response, leaving shelter operations without effective MACC support during overnight hours.

Analysis

The Incident Support Model is a recognized framework under NIMS for defining how an EOC or coordination center supports field operations: which departments play which roles at which activation levels, who has authority to commit county resources, and how overnight coverage and staff rotation are managed. Its absence is not a minor administrative gap; it is the structural root cause underlying the improvised command arrangements, the overnight MACC communications failure, and the self-deployment into operational calls that characterized the Blizzard Hernando response.

Recommendations

1. Formalize the ISM defining roles and responsibilities for all county departments and staff within the MACC/EOC structure.
2. Develop and document a MACC/EOC overnight and extended-activation staffing model with defined on-call coverage levels and resource request protocols.
3. Develop a documented staff rotation plan for extended activations, including defined trigger points for command transition and handoff procedures.
4. Establish clear protocols for elected official participation during activations, including pre-event briefings separate from operational calls.

Focus Area 7: Organizational Culture

The organizational culture focus area addresses how Barnstable County prepares, equips, and supports its staff in their emergency management roles. These findings are cross-cutting: the training deficits, skills inventory gaps, and role clarity problems described here contributed to vulnerabilities across every other focus area of this review.

Finding 7.1 – Area for Improvement

County staff lack the training, credentialing, pre-event preparation, and role clarity needed to fill emergency positions effectively, and no system exists to identify who can fill specialized roles during an activation.

Supporting Observations

Observation #29 [Strength]: County staff demonstrated extraordinary flexibility, willingness, and commitment by stepping outside their normal roles to sustain operations, widely cited as the single most consistent strength of the response across all survey respondents.

Observation #41 [Area for Improvement]: Most county staff deployed to shelters had no prior training in ICS, shelter operations, or their specific assigned roles, and some were assigned tasks they had never performed before upon arrival.

Observation #42 [Area for Improvement]: No county-wide inventory of employee skills, certifications, and emergency qualifications exists, making it impossible to systematically identify who can fill medical, food safety, communications, or other specialized roles during an activation.

Observation #43 [Area for Improvement]: Staff expectations during county emergency closures, including whether to work remotely, report in person, or stand by, were unclear, and no formal system existed for assessing staff availability, capacity, or personal situation prior to deployment.

Analysis

NIMS establishes ICS 100, 200, 700, and 800 as baseline training expectations for emergency management personnel and identifies personnel qualification as a core capability element. EMAP Standards address emergency management program personnel requirements, including training, credentialing, and exercises. Survey Likert data from Blizzard Hernando showed widespread disagreement with the statement that staff felt adequately trained and prepared, a result that is not surprising given that many staff were assigned roles they had never performed without job action sheets, ICS orientation, or prior notification of what would be expected.

The extraordinary commitment and flexibility of county staff during Blizzard Hernando (cited independently by more than ten survey respondents as the single most consistent strength of the response) compensated for structural training gaps that individual willingness cannot be relied upon to fill indefinitely. Building a staff skills and credentials inventory is a low-cost administrative task that

produces immediate operational value: the ability to systematically identify who can fill medical, food safety, communications, and other specialized roles during an activation, rather than hoping the right people happen to self-identify.

Recommendations

1. Require ICS 100, 200, 700, and 800 as baseline certifications for all positions with emergency responsibilities; reflect requirements in job descriptions.
2. Develop and maintain a county-wide staff skills and credentials inventory covering medical licenses, food safety certifications, language skills, ICS levels, and prior emergency experience.
3. Establish a proactive pre-event staff readiness check process to assess availability, capacity, and personal situation before deployment.
4. Develop and distribute job action sheets for all MACC/EOC and shelter roles; conduct at minimum one annual tabletop exercise.
5. Explore incentive structures for employees, particularly exempt employees, to serve in emergency capacities, including recognition programs or compensation frameworks that reflect the additional demands of activation service.
6. Ensure Critical Incident Stress Management (CISM) support is made available to staff following significant activations.

Conclusion

Blizzard Hernando was a significant test of Barnstable County's support capacity and its integration with the BCREPC. County staff, AmeriCorps members, town staff, and partner organizations responded with extraordinary commitment and adaptability, compensating through individual effort for structural gaps that need to be resolved before the next storm. That compensation is both a tribute to the people involved and a warning: the region cannot continue to rely on individual willingness to absorb the consequences of institutional deficiencies.

Most of the findings in this report describe problems that predated Blizzard Hernando. The 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan was already outdated before the blizzard struck. The lines between the BCREPC and the county staff that support it were already blurred, leading to an assumption of county ownership and capability that did not exist. The MACC structure was already outdated, and the county staff's role had never been formalized after filling in the gaps. ICS training had never been required for most county personnel. The blizzard made these deficiencies operational rather than theoretical. The cost was borne by staff working shifts of 20 or more hours, AmeriCorps members performing personal care tasks they were never trained for, and confusion and frustration for our partners and volunteers.

The path forward is clear. The county has identified what needs to change. The priority is now to act before the next storm season, while the experience is fresh and the motivation is present. The measure of this review's success will not be the quality of this document, but the state of the county's emergency management system when the next event tests it.

Appendices

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Appendix A: Acronyms

The following acronyms appear in this After-Action Report.

Acronym	Definition
AAR	After-Action Report
ARES	Amateur Radio Emergency Service
ARC	American Red Cross
BCAHIMT	Barnstable County All-Hazards Incident Management Team
BCDHE	Barnstable County Department of Health and Environment
BCREPC	Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee
CCRTA	Cape Cod Regional Transit Authority
CERT	Community Emergency Response Team
CITAP	Continuous Improvement Technical Assistance Program
CNA	Certified Nursing Assistant
CORI	Criminal Offender Record Information
CPG	Comprehensive Preparedness Guide
EMAP	Emergency Management Accreditation Program
EMS	Emergency Medical Services
EMT	Emergency Medical Technician
EOC	Emergency Operations Center
EPCRA	Emergency Planning and Community Right-to-Know Act
FEMA	Federal Emergency Management Agency
FNSS	Functional Needs Support Services
HSEEP	Homeland Security Exercise and Evaluation Program
ICS	Incident Command System
IP	Improvement Plan

Acronym	Definition
IPPW	Integrated Preparedness Planning Workshop
ISM	Incident Support Model
JIC	Joint Information Center
MACC	Multi-Agency Coordination Center
MEMA	Massachusetts Emergency Management Agency
MOA	Memorandum of Agreement
MOU	Memorandum of Understanding
MRC	Medical Reserve Corps
NIMS	National Incident Management System
NRF	National Response Framework
PBP	Potential Best Practice
PIO	Public Information Officer
REPC	Regional Emergency Planning Committee
RSP	Regional Sheltering Plan
SARA	Superfund Amendments and Reauthorization Act
SEOC	State Emergency Operations Center
SRAC	Southeast Regional Homeland Security Advisory Council
THIRA	Threat and Hazard Identification and Risk Assessment
VOAD	Voluntary Organizations Active in Disaster

Appendix B: Glossary

The following terms are used throughout this After-Action Report.

Term	Definition
After-Action Report (AAR)	A formal document produced after an emergency event or exercise that identifies strengths, areas for improvement, and specific corrective actions.
Area for Improvement (AFI)	A finding category describing activities that resulted in outcomes that did not meet expectations.
Concept of Operations (ConOps)	A document describing how an organization intends to operate in a specific situation, outlining roles and responsibilities without the full detail of an Emergency Operations Plan.
Emergency Operations Plan (EOP)	A comprehensive, scalable plan documenting how a jurisdiction will mobilize resources and conduct operations during an emergency. Developed in accordance with CPG 101.
Functional Needs Support Services (FNSS)	Services enabling individuals to maintain independence in a general population shelter, including personal assistance, durable medical equipment, and communication accommodations for persons with disabilities.
Incident Command System (ICS)	A standardized, all-hazard incident management approach allowing for the integration of facilities, equipment, personnel, procedures, and communications under a common organizational structure.
Incident Support Model (ISM)	A framework defining how an Emergency Operations Center or MACC organizes and supports field operations, specifying departmental roles at different activation levels.
Job Action Sheet	A one-page reference outlining duties and responsibilities for a specific emergency response position within an ICS structure.
Mass Care	Assistance provided to meet the basic human needs of people impacted by a catastrophic event, including shelter, food, water, and other essential life-support needs.
MACC (Multi-Agency Coordination Center)	Barnstable County's emergency coordination facility that serves as the regional clearinghouse for information, resource coordination, and decision-making during activations.
Mission Critical	A finding category describing issues with significant operational effects that may lead to mission failure or harm. Requires immediate attention from senior leadership.

Term	Definition
National Incident Management System (NIMS)	A comprehensive, national approach to incident management establishing a common framework for government, private sector, and nongovernmental organizations to work together during incidents.
Potential Best Practice (PBP)	A finding category describing activities outside established policy that yielded better-than-expected results and are candidates for broader adoption.
Regional Sheltering Plan (RSP)	The BCREPC's governing document for the regional shelter system on Cape Cod, establishing roles, responsibilities, and procedures for shelter activation and operations.
ServSafe	A nationally recognized food safety training and certification program, required for professional food service supervisors.
Strength	A finding category describing activities within policy or guidance that yielded the desired result and should be sustained and institutionalized.
Whole Community	A FEMA planning principle recognizing that effective preparedness requires engaging all members of the community, including people with disabilities, persons with limited English proficiency, and others with access and functional needs.

Appendix C: References

Footnotes throughout this report provide specific citations. The following is a consolidated reference list.

- American Red Cross. Functional Needs Support Services (FNSS) in General Population Shelters: A Reference Guide. Washington, D.C.: American Red Cross, 2012.
- American Red Cross. Safe and Well: Food Safety in Shelters. Washington, D.C.: American Red Cross, 2019.
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- Juvare. WebEOC Enterprise: Emergency Management Software. Atlanta, GA: Juvare, 2024. https://www.juvare.com/webeoc/.
- National Restaurant Association Educational Foundation. ServSafe Manager Certification Program, 7th ed. Chicago: NRAEF, 2017. https://www.servsafe.com.
- National Voluntary Organizations Active in Disaster (National VOAD). About National VOAD. Accessed May 2026. https://www.nvoad.org.

Appendix D: BCREPC Regional Sheltering Plan (2017)

The Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee Regional Sheltering Plan (2017) is incorporated by reference into this After-Action Report.

[The full text of the Regional Sheltering Plan is attached as a separate PDF. A copy is on file with the Barnstable County Emergency Management Division and the BCREPC Coordinator.]

Appendix E: BCREPC By-Laws (November 10, 2015)

The By-Laws of the Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee (adopted November 10, 2015) are incorporated by reference into this After-Action Report.

[The full text of the BCREPC By-Laws is attached as a separate PDF. A copy is on file with the BCREPC Coordinator and the Barnstable County Emergency Management Division.]

Appendix F: BCREPC Membership

Appointed members of the Barnstable County Regional Emergency Planning Committee as of July 2026.

Role / Category	Name	Organization
Co-Chair	Chief Heath Eldredge	Cape & Islands Police Chiefs Association
Co-Chair	Chief Peter Burke	Cape & Islands Fire Chiefs Association
BCREP Coordinator / Clerk (non-voting)	Open	
Elected Official	Open	
Law Enforcement	*Chief Heath Eldredge*	*Brewster Police Department*
Emergency Management	*Chief Justin Tavano*	*Chatham Fire Rescue Department*
Fire	*Chief Peter Burke*	*Hyannis Fire Department*
First Aid / EMS	*Chief Justin Tavano*	*Chatham Fire Rescue Department*
Health Agencies	Judy Giorgio	Health Agents Coalition / Town of Chatham
Environmental Groups	Open	
Hospital / Health Care	Frank Riccio	Cape Cod Healthcare
Media	Theresa Martin	Lower Cape TV
Community Groups	Dave Miller	Brewster-Harwich-Orleans-Chatham Community Emergency Response Team
Tier II Facility Owners / Operators	Phil Goddard	Town of Bourne Integrated Solid Waste Management
Disaster Relief Agencies	Maria Zuniga	American Red Cross
Transportation Agencies	Open	
Regional Communications	*Tom Ashe*	*Barnstable County Sheriff's Office*
Barnstable County Sheriff's Office	Tom Ashe	Barnstable County Sheriff's Office

Role / Category	Name	Organization
Barnstable County Representative	Jay Gardner	Barnstable County Department of Health and Environment
Barnstable (Town)	Chief Jean Challies	Barnstable Police Department
Bourne (Town)	Chief Brandon Esip	Bourne Police Department
Brewster (Town)	Chief Kevin Varley	Brewster Fire Department
Chatham (Town)	Chief Justin Tavano	Chatham Fire Rescue Department
Dennis (Town)	Chief John Brady	Dennis Police Department
Eastham (Town)	Chief Adam Bohannon	Eastham Police Department
Falmouth (Town)	Deputy Chief Chad Absted	Falmouth Fire Rescue Department
Harwich (Town)	Deputy Chief Craig Thornton	Harwich Fire Department
Mashpee (Town)	Open	
Nantucket (Town)	Chief Jody Kasper	Nantucket Police Department
Orleans (Town)	Chief Geoff Deering	Orleans Fire Rescue Department
Provincetown (Town)	Sherry Prada	Town of Provincetown
Sandwich (Town)	Chief John Burke	Sandwich Fire Department
Truro (Town)	Chief Tim Collins	Truro Fire Department
Wellfleet (Town)	Chief Kevin Larocco	Wellfleet Fire & Rescue Department
Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe	Open	
Yarmouth (Town)	Chief Enrique Arrascue	Yarmouth Fire Department

Italicized indicated duplicated roles